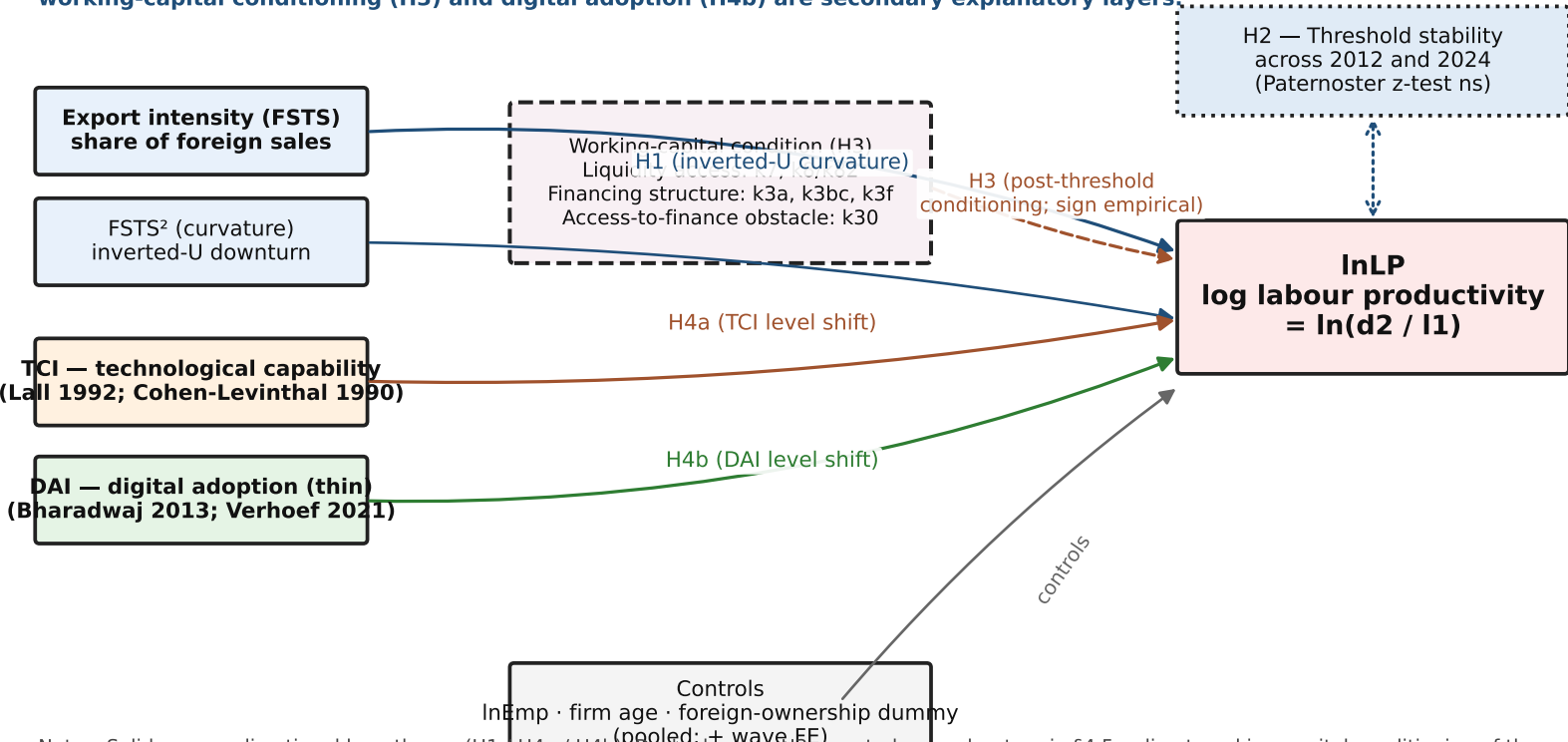


Figure 1. Conceptual model — Threshold stability and bounded internationalisation-performance

Chinese manufacturing SMEs (WBES 2012 + 2024)

P5 architecture (Option C+): threshold stability is the central contribution;
working-capital conditioning (H3) and digital adoption (H4b) are secondary explanatory layers



Notes. Solid arrows: directional hypotheses (H1 / H4a / H4b). Dashed arrow: H3 reported as exploratory in §4.5— direct working-capital conditioning of the post-threshold downturn classified as NULL; interpretation retained as theoretically grounded mechanism. Dotted double-headed arrow links the H1 curvature finding to the H2 cross-wave stability test. All specifications estimated by OLS-HC1; see §3 for variable construction and verification protocol.